



EQUITY RESEARCH

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SpaceX

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SpaceX

Rocket and satellite company offering low-cost launches and global internet via Starlink

#space

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Details

HEADQUARTERS
Hawthorne, CA

CEO
Elon Musk



REVENUE

\$18,700,000,000

2025

VALUATION

\$800,000,000,000

2026

FUNDING

\$12,000,000,000

2025

GROWTH RATE (Y/Y)

63%

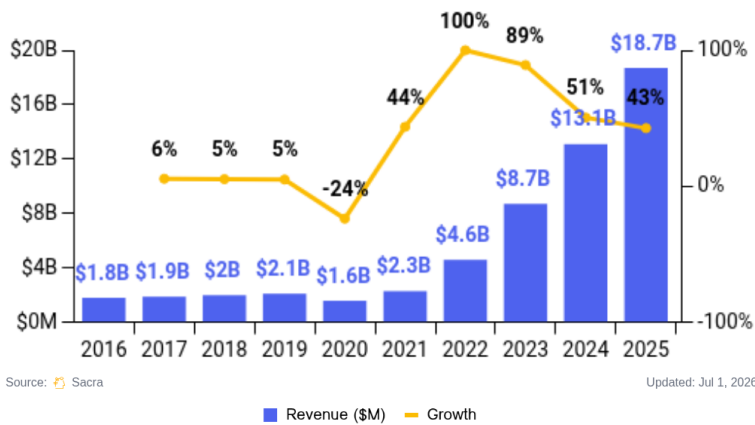
2024

Revenue



\$18.7B

↑ 42.7% YoY



Sacra estimates SpaceX generated \$18.7B in revenue in 2025, up 43% YoY from \$13.1B in 2024. Draft IPO prospectus reporting puts SpaceX at \$6.6B of adjusted EBITDA in 2025 but a \$4.9B GAAP net loss, driven by capex, stock-based compensation, debt, and the inclusion of X/xAI-related AI losses.

Starlink accounted for \$11.4B of revenue in 2025, up 48% from \$7.7B in 2024 and representing 61% of total revenue. Starlink also generated \$4.4B of operating profit, making it SpaceX's core profit center even as the broader company reported a GAAP loss.

Since launching in beta with 10,000 users in 2021, Starlink grew to 1M users in 2022, 2.3M in 2023, 4.6M in 2024, and 9M+ by the end of 2025 after adding more than 4.6M active customers during the year. By February 2026, SpaceX reported Starlink had surpassed 10M active customers across 160 countries, territories, and markets. The draft IPO prospectus disclosed that average revenue per subscriber fell 18% to \$81/month between 2023 and 2025, even as the individual subscriber base quadrupled, reflecting a deliberate trade of ARPU for global volume. In May 2026, SpaceX reversed that trend by raising Starlink plan prices by up to \$10/month, signaling a shift toward monetizing its installed base following the period of aggressive subscriber growth.

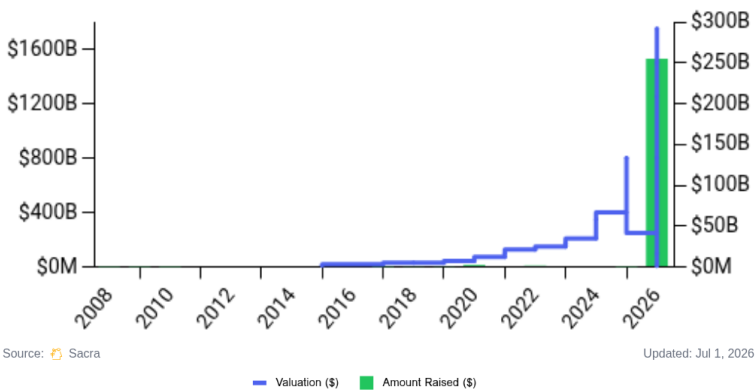
SpaceX's Space segment, which includes revenue from rocket launches for outside customers, generated \$4.1B in 2025, up just 8% YoY, primarily from Pentagon and NASA contracts. The relatively slow growth was not because launch activity was low: SpaceX completed 165 Falcon 9 launches, but only 43 were for outside customers, with nearly three-quarters used internally for Starlink.

Valuation & Funding



\$97.0B

↑ \$262.1B Total Raised



SpaceX completed its IPO on June 12, 2026, opening at \$150 per share—an 11% pop from its \$135 offering price. On June 15, SpaceX confirmed it had closed the sale of 638,888,888 Class A shares including the underwriters' full option, raising approximately \$85.7B in gross proceeds—the largest US IPO on record. The listing reached a post-IPO valuation of \$2.3 trillion. Robinhood reported record-breaking platform traffic on debut day, reflecting broad retail demand. SpaceX President Gwynne Shotwell hinted at a potential Tesla merger shortly after the debut.

The IPO was preceded by a confidential filing on April 1, 2026, with initial valuation targets of approximately \$1.75 trillion and a planned \$75B raise across 21 banks; Bloomberg subsequently reported the target was raised above \$2T ahead of the June offering. The filing disclosed super-voting Class B shares carrying 10 votes per share; after the offering, Elon Musk retains approximately 83.5–83.6% of the company's voting power, leaving SpaceX classified as a controlled company under Nasdaq rules. Morgan Stanley—whose veteran dealmaker Michael Grimes rejoined as chairman of investment banking in February 2026 specifically for the listing—led alongside Goldman Sachs and JPMorgan. Days after the IPO, SpaceX appointed Roelof Botha (Sequoia Capital) as an independent common stock director and audit committee member, filling a pre-existing board vacancy.

In May 2026, SpaceX executed a 5-for-1 stock split following shareholder approval, adjusting the per-share fair market value from \$526.59 to approximately \$105.32 ahead of the offering. Separately, Brookfield amassed a \$2B pre-IPO stake through its balance sheet and affiliated entities.

In February 2026, SpaceX acquired xAI in an all-stock deal valued at approximately \$1.25 trillion combined—SpaceX at roughly \$1T and xAI at roughly \$250B at the time of the deal.

SpaceX's valuation reached approximately \$800 billion in December 2025 through an insider share sale at \$421 per share, up sharply from approximately \$400 billion in July 2025 at \$212 per share. Previously, SpaceX reached a \$350 billion valuation in December 2024 through a \$1.25 billion secondary share sale at \$185 per share.

Founded in 2002, SpaceX has raised approximately \$12 billion in primary funding to date, with its most recent primary round in January 2023 bringing in \$750 million at a \$137 billion valuation. Elon Musk retains majority ownership, while significant investors include Founders Fund, Fidelity Investments, and Google Ventures.

Product

SpaceX was founded in 2002 by Elon Musk with the initial goal of reducing space transportation costs to enable the colonization of Mars. The company began by developing its first orbital rocket, the Falcon 1, from scratch, and found product-market fit as a low-cost satellite launch provider for NASA and commercial satellite operators—offering reliable access to space at a fraction of incumbent prices through innovative reusable rocket technology. The breakthrough came in 2008 when NASA awarded SpaceX a \$1.6 billion contract for cargo resupply missions to the International Space Station.

Today SpaceX operates three integrated product lines—launch services, Starlink satellite internet, and the Dragon spacecraft—that share common technology and manufacturing processes, forming a unified space transportation and communications platform. The Starshield government division, nascent Terafab semiconductor initiative, and an AI consumer device prototype extend this platform into secure communications, sensing, vertically integrated chip supply, and consumer wireless hardware.

Launch Services

SpaceX revolutionized the launch industry by achieving 5–10x lower cost per ton than competitors through its reusable Falcon 9 rocket, which has completed over 260 successful re-flights out of 315 total launches, allowing the company to amortize the \$62M launch cost across multiple missions while maintaining a >99% success rate. This cost advantage has made SpaceX the dominant launch provider, accounting for roughly 85% of U.S. orbital launches in 2025.

SpaceX's entry into the launch market challenged United Launch Alliance's (ULA) effective monopoly on U.S. government launches, where the Boeing-Lockheed Martin joint venture's reliance on 1,200+ subcontractors and specialized components had driven the cost of launching satellites to over \$400M per mission. By vertically integrating 70% of Falcon 9 production in-house at its Hawthorne facility and using commercial-grade components that met low Earth orbit requirements—for example, replacing a \$100,000 industry-standard radio with a \$5,000 commercial alternative—SpaceX reduced costs dramatically while maintaining reliability through iterative design improvements that culminated in their first NASA contract in 2006.

SpaceX completed 165 orbital launches in 2025, its sixth consecutive annual launch record, with the 500th Falcon 9 launch marking a booster flying for a record 29th reuse. That launch cadence enabled SpaceX to self-fund its Starlink constellation deployment, including 63 dedicated Starlink launches in a single year, while still serving dozens of commercial and government customers annually. The government launch portfolio continues to expand, anchored by a \$2B Pentagon satellite contract under the Golden Dome program to develop an air moving target indicator system that could field up to 600 satellites, with SpaceX also expected to participate in Milnet and a ground-tracking constellation.

The next-generation Starship program underpins SpaceX's long-term launch ambitions. The FAA has authorized SpaceX to increase its launch cadence at Starbase, Texas from 5 to up to 25 launches per year, and SpaceX is scouting U.S. and overseas spaceport sites to support a Starship fleet capable of thousands of launches annually, scaling commercial launch infrastructure ahead of its planned IPO.

Starlink

Starlink, SpaceX's satellite internet division launched commercially in 2021, has grown to over 12 million subscribers across residential, maritime, and aviation customers, with service available in 35 additional countries, territories, and markets. The FCC has authorized a total Gen2 constellation of 15,000 satellites, providing a long runway for capacity and coverage expansion.

While traditional satellite providers like Viasat and Intelsat serve specific market niches with geostationary satellites offering speeds of roughly 20 Mbps, Starlink's low Earth orbit constellation provides lower latency (25–60ms) and faster speeds (up to 215 Mbps), enabling streaming, gaming, and video calls that were previously impossible via satellite. Starlink's competitive advantage stems from its novel satellite architecture: thousands of small satellites at 342 miles altitude communicate via laser links to form a mesh network, enabling data to travel through space at the speed of light rather than bouncing between ground stations. The constellation's density allows Starlink to serve up to 4,000 customers per satellite, while its \$600 user terminals—down from \$3,000 at launch—automatically track overhead satellites using a phased array antenna that can switch connections in milliseconds as satellites pass overhead.

Starlink's business model has evolved from simple residential internet (\$110/month) to a multi-tiered offering spanning consumer, enterprise, and government segments. Premium services such as Maritime (\$250/month) and Aviation (\$25,000/month) drive higher average revenue per user, while partnerships with major airlines—including United (350 planes) and American Airlines (500+ Airbus aircraft)—and mobile carriers like T-Mobile validate the technology and expand distribution.

A major strategic frontier is direct-to-phone connectivity, which eliminates the need for dedicated user terminals by allowing standard smartphones to connect directly to Starlink satellites. T-Mobile's T-Satellite service is now commercially live nationwide, covering 500,000+ square miles of U.S. territory unreachable by terrestrial towers at \$10/month, backed by 657+ Starlink direct-to-cell satellites, with coverage expanding from messaging to data for supported apps including WhatsApp, Google Maps, and Apple Music. SpaceX has bolstered this push through its acquisition of EchoStar's AWS-4 and H-block wireless spectrum licenses—structured as up to \$8.5B cash plus up to \$8.5B in SpaceX stock, plus approximately \$2B of EchoStar debt-interest support through November 2027, with a long-term commercial arrangement enabling Boost Mobile subscribers to access next-generation Starlink Direct to Cell—significantly accelerating its move into mobile network services globally.

Starshield

Starshield, SpaceX's government-focused satellite division, forms a third pillar alongside launch services and Starlink, targeting enterprise-grade, mission-critical secure communications and reconnaissance needs for U.S. agencies. The division builds on a foundation of Space Force awards and ongoing classified deployments, and has expanded further through a NASA pilot program testing the service, formalizing Starshield as a distinct product line aimed at secure communications and sensing for U.S. government customers.

Terafab and AI Compute Satellites

SpaceX's vertical integration ambitions now extend into semiconductor manufacturing through Terafab, a multi-phase chip fabrication facility planned for Texas with a projected cost of up to \$119B, alongside a buildout of AI compute satellites and related space facilities. Terafab is designed to supply chips for a planned constellation of up to one million AI data-center satellites that would harvest solar power in orbit to address terrestrial data center power constraints, positioning SpaceX as a vertically integrated competitor spanning launch, connectivity, compute, and semiconductor manufacturing.

AI Consumer Device

SpaceX has shown investors a phone-like AI device prototype, signaling an intent to enter consumer wireless hardware. The device would connect to Starlink's direct-to-cell network and incorporate AI capabilities derived from the xAI merger, extending SpaceX's vertical stack from satellite and spectrum ownership down to the handset itself.

Business Model



SpaceX's key early insight was that it could use launch services (provided both to governments and commercial enterprises) as a revenue-generating engine to finance their larger vision of building increasingly advanced spacecraft capable of cheaper and more frequent trips into space.

SpaceX's business model operates as a self-reinforcing flywheel where launch services revenue (\$5.5B in 2024) funds R&D for increasingly advanced reusable spacecraft, which in turn enables cheaper launches and the deployment of new revenue streams like Starlink (\$7.7B in 2024), now generating 58% of total revenue with higher margins than the launch business.

The cash flow from bringing countries' and other companies' satellites into space—\$10-\$12 million per launch for the early Falcon 1 launches—saved SpaceX in its early days when it looked like a succession of mission failures might destroy the company. Today, the standard commercial Falcon 9 launch costs roughly \$60M, while Falcon Heavy launches cost about \$125M each.

For now, SpaceX has the luxury of setting prices based on the next-best alternative versus its own operational costs—a model which allows SpaceX healthy profit margins.

Vertical integration

SpaceX's manufacturing approach stands in stark contrast to traditional aerospace companies, with its 1-million-square-foot Hawthorne facility producing everything from Merlin engines to flight computers, while competitors like United Launch Alliance rely on complex networks of 1,200+ suppliers that drive up costs and slow innovation.

This vertically-integrated manufacturing model has allowed SpaceX to dramatically reduce component costs—for example, producing onboard radios for \$5,000 versus the industry standard \$100,000—while enabling rapid design iterations and quality control that helped achieve their 99% launch success rate across 315 missions.

SpaceX's vertical integration strategy extends beyond just manufacturing, with the company controlling its entire value chain from rocket design and production (70% in-house) to launch operations, ground station networks, and even operating its own spaceports in Texas and Florida.

This end-to-end control has allowed SpaceX to reduce a typical satellite launch cost from \$400M to \$62M, while enabling unique capabilities like recovering rockets on autonomous drone ships and developing proprietary technologies like the Raptor engine, which costs \$1M compared to competitors' \$20M+ engines.

Competition

SpaceX competes across three increasingly interconnected markets: launch services, where reusable rockets have reset cost and cadence expectations; satellite connectivity, where Starlink's constellation scale defines the bar for LEO broadband; and direct-to-cell, where mobile network operators are choosing between satellite partners to fill coverage gaps.

Across all three, SpaceX's core advantage is vertical integration—designing, manufacturing, and operating everything from engines to user terminals—which compresses costs and accelerates iteration. Competitors respond either with sovereign scale, fresh capital, or specialized positioning in specific market segments.

Launch: startups and domestic incumbents

Blue Origin represents the most credible near-term commercial threat to Falcon's dominance. New Glenn, Blue's heavy-lift rocket designed for reusability, offers U.S. government and commercial customers a genuine "second source"—critical for national security missions that require launch redundancy. Blue Origin has developed a larger, more powerful New Glenn variant targeting mega-constellations, lunar and deep-space missions, and national-security programs including Golden Dome, positioning it closer to both the Falcon family and Starship on the performance curve. Blue's \$10B+ in funding from Jeff Bezos and vertical integration (in-house BE-4 engines, manufacturing facilities) mirror SpaceX's playbook, though New Glenn has yet to demonstrate operational reuse at scale.

United Launch Alliance (Vulcan) serves as the U.S. government's risk-averse option, with deep mission assurance heritage and security clearances that make it indispensable for the most sensitive national security payloads. However, ULA's traditional supply chain—relying on hundreds of subcontractors and non-reusable hardware—keeps costs structurally higher than Falcon 9's ~\$62M price point. Vulcan's role is less about competing on price than maintaining a sovereign industrial base and providing assured access when SpaceX faces delays or capacity constraints.

Rocket Lab (Neutron) is explicitly targeting the mid-lift market with a promise of "meaningfully lower costs than Falcon 9" through aggressive reuse and simplified operations. Having established credibility with 50+ successful Electron launches, Rocket Lab is moving upmarket to serve constellation operators and government missions that don't need Falcon Heavy's lift capacity. If Neutron delivers on its cost and cadence targets when it begins flying in 2026, it could pressure Falcon 9 pricing at the margin and capture customers seeking diversification.

Next-generation ventures like Relativity Space (Terran R with 3D-printed components), Stoke Space (100% reusable rocket), Firefly, and ABL target specialized niches—rapid response, small/medium lift, experimental propulsion—that could expand customer choice and put marginal pressure on Falcon pricing if they achieve operational scale.

Launch: sovereign companies

China's CASC (Long March family) poses the most significant long-term competitive threat on sheer volume. With 156 launches in 2023—more than the rest of the world combined outside of SpaceX—and vertically integrated state-backed manufacturing, China is rapidly building reusable launch capability while subsidizing commercial prices to gain international market share. China's ability to mobilize industrial capacity at scale, combined with Belt and Road diplomatic ties, makes CASC a formidable competitor in commercial and sovereign launch markets outside the U.S. alliance network.

Regional sovereign programs—ArianeGroup (Ariane 6), ISRO (India's PSLV/GSLV), JAXA (H3)—anchor Europe, India, and Japan's independent space access but face structural cost and cadence disadvantages versus Falcon's reuse flywheel. These programs exist primarily to maintain strategic autonomy rather than compete on commercial economics, though India's ISRO has carved out a niche in small satellite launches at competitive prices.

Starlink: LEO constellation economics vs. capital and distribution

Amazon's Amazon Leo (formerly Project Kuiper) is the only competitor with resources and strategic positioning to potentially match Starlink's flywheel. Amazon's \$10B commitment, retail/Prime distribution reach, AWS cloud integration, and device partnerships create a plausible path to LEO broadband at scale, with full-scale satellite deployment now underway across 80+ launches from Arianespace, Blue Origin, SpaceX, and ULA. Amazon has also agreed to acquire Globalstar for \$11.57B, adding terrestrial spectrum and direct-to-device capabilities to its satellite broadband stack and sharpening its competitive posture against Starlink across both fixed broadband and direct-to-cell. Every quarter of delay in constellation buildout widens Starlink's lead in network effects, terminal cost curves, and customer lock-in.

Eutelsat OneWeb and Telesat Lightspeed offer enterprise-focused alternatives with differentiated positioning—OneWeb emphasizes government/military contracts and polar coverage, while Telesat targets high-value backhaul and enterprise connectivity. Both operate at smaller constellation scales than Starlink (OneWeb has ~600 satellites deployed vs. Starlink's 7,000+), which limits throughput and coverage density but also reduces capital requirements for focused market segments.

Traditional GEO incumbents—Viasat and Intelsat—defend installed bases in aviation, maritime, and enterprise through long-term contracts and hybrid LEO-GEO network upgrades. While Viasat's ~20Mbps speeds and higher latency can't match Starlink's 215Mbps and 25–60ms performance, these incumbents retain advantages in regulatory relationships, existing antenna installations on aircraft and ships, and SLA-driven enterprise relationships. The question is whether they can upgrade infrastructure fast enough to retain customers as Starlink's maritime and aviation offerings mature.

The core dynamic favoring Starlink is manufacturing scale: SpaceX produces satellites, launches them on owned rockets, and controls the full stack from ground stations to user terminals. This vertical integration drives terminal costs down faster than competitors can match, while constellation density creates network effects that make service quality self-reinforcing. Competitors must either match this capital intensity (Amazon Leo) or find defensible niches (OneWeb's government focus, GEO players' installed base).

Direct-to-cell: spectrum, MNO partnerships, and potential vertical integration

AST SpaceMobile leads the non-SpaceX "satellite-to-standard-phone" approach, with partnerships spanning AT&T, Verizon, Vodafone, and other global carriers. AST's BlueWalker 3 test satellite demonstrated direct-to-unmodified-phone connectivity in 2023, and the company is racing to deploy its commercial constellation. The competitive battleground is who controls the billing relationship: AT&T customers using AST's network likely pay AT&T, not AST, cementing the carrier's customer ownership while AST captures wholesale connectivity fees.

Lynk Global and Apple/Globalstar (iPhone satellite messaging) represent parallel efforts to enable satellite connectivity on consumer devices. Apple's existing Globalstar integration for emergency SOS proves consumer willingness to pay for backup connectivity; Globalstar's pending acquisition by Amazon for \$11.57B would fold that spectrum and device integration into Amazon Leo's competitive stack.

SpaceX's T-Mobile partnership is the furthest along of any direct-to-cell arrangement, with T-Satellite commercially live and expanded to data connectivity for supported apps. SpaceX is exploring a potential acquisition of T-Mobile outright if wholesale network deals prove insufficient to fully control Starlink Mobile's distribution and quality—a move that would vertically integrate a major U.S. carrier into the SpaceX stack and fundamentally shift the competitive dynamic from partnership to ownership across the mobile market.

The long-term competitive question is multi-homing: mobile carriers will likely partner with multiple satellite providers to ensure coverage redundancy and price competition. AT&T with AST, T-Mobile with SpaceX, Verizon potentially with Amazon Leo creates a fragmented landscape where satellite operators compete on spectrum holdings, constellation density, and wholesale pricing rather than direct customer relationships—though a SpaceX/T-Mobile combination would collapse that dynamic for a significant share of the U.S. market.

Adjacent platform plays: co-opetition for orbital infrastructure

Axiom Space, Vast, and other commercial station developers aren't direct SpaceX competitors—SpaceX could be their launch provider and logistics partner—but they compete for the same pool of NASA funding (~\$3B+ annually in ISS-replacement budget) and define who controls orbital platform economics. If Axiom builds and operates the dominant commercial station, they capture the high-margin space (astronaut training, research facilities, tourism experiences) while SpaceX remains a transport provider. If SpaceX builds its own orbital platforms using Starship, it vertically integrates up the value chain.

Varda Space and other in-space manufacturing ventures similarly create tension: they're anchor launch customers for SpaceX (positive for launch revenue) but also establish who owns the interfaces and IP around orbital manufacturing. If pharmaceutical production in microgravity becomes a \$10B+ market as projected, the question is whether SpaceX provides just the "launch and return" service or builds competing manufacturing platforms.

In-orbit service providers—Astroscale (debris removal), Impulse Space (orbital tugs), Northrop Grumman (satellite servicing)—influence constellation lifecycle economics by enabling satellite refueling, repositioning, and retirement. SpaceX could internalize these capabilities for Starlink or partner with specialists. The competitive dynamic is whether a specialized third-party ecosystem emerges or whether SpaceX's vertical integration extends to constellation servicing.

TAM Expansion

The coming commodification of launch services means that the real exciting long-term vision of SpaceX hinges on what can be done with a cost-efficient, reusable platform in space.

The total size of the space economy has been estimated at roughly \$400B to \$500B as of 2023, and it's expected to grow to at least \$1T by the year 2030.

SpaceX, knowing that competition will drive down the margins on launch services much as it did in passenger air travel, is already thinking about how it can own a larger slice of that space economy and build more recurring revenue businesses that can generate higher-margin cashflow over the long-term. Starlink is their first play in this direction—but there will be more businesses to come in the future.

Mobile network ownership

SpaceX is exploring a potential acquisition of T-Mobile—which has roughly 130 million subscribers and operates the largest 5G network in the U.S. by coverage—as a way to own the terrestrial wireless distribution layer for Starlink Mobile rather than depending on wholesale carrier arrangements. A combined SpaceX/T-Mobile entity would control spectrum from LEO orbit down to the handset, enabling SpaceX to compete directly against AT&T and Verizon across both satellite and cellular connectivity in a market generating over \$200B in annual U.S. wireless service revenue.

AI consumer hardware

In July 2026, SpaceX revealed a phone-like AI device prototype to investors, pointing toward a consumer electronics category that would integrate Starlink direct-to-cell connectivity with xAI capabilities at the device layer. Owning the handset would allow SpaceX to capture hardware margin, control the subscriber relationship, and compete in the global smartphone and AI device market—a category generating over \$500B in annual revenue—without relying on third-party OEMs.

Space manufacturing

By lowering the cost per kilogram to low Earth orbit, SpaceX opens up new possibilities for potentially highly valuable space manufacturing.

Space manufacturing is compelling because certain kinds of materials can only be produced in microgravity conditions—by reducing the cost to launch into space, SpaceX has made it so that raw materials and machinery can be sent to space, with finished goods brought back to Earth, at a cost that makes the whole operation financially viable.

A few examples of the kinds of products that could be lucrative to produce in space include:

Pharmaceuticals: Gravity can cause impurities in certain drugs unless they are produced in vacuums, making their manufacture on Earth expensive. The market for drugs produced in space is projected to hit \$10B by 2030.

ZBLAN fiber optic cables: ZBLAN fibers, which are far easier to produce in microgravity, are used in high-precision applications like spectroscopy and laser power due to their higher bandwidth and far superior transmittance. The market for their manufacture is expected to hit \$12B by 2025.

Silicon wafers: Silicon wafers for the construction of computer chips are significantly easier to produce in high quality in microgravity, thanks to the way that it prevents defects from forming. The global market for silicon wafers was around \$93 billion in 2020 and is expected to surpass \$150B by 2025.

Space tourism

Space tourism is gradually becoming a feasible market, and SpaceX could play a significant role in its development. The market currently offers a variety of experiences, ranging from Earth-based activities to suborbital and orbital flights. The cost has typically been the major barrier, with experiences like Virgin Galactic's costing hundreds of thousands of dollars, but SpaceX has the opportunity to bring costs down and make space tourism more commonplace.

SpaceX's reusable technology could be instrumental in reducing costs. Estimates put the value of the global space tourism market at about \$870M in 2022 and project it to grow to almost \$4B in 2032 with a CAGR of 16%.

Space stations

The International Space Station (ISS), governed by a multinational treaty, has been a cornerstone for space activities since its inception. With the ISS nearing the end of its functional lifespan, a vacancy in low Earth orbit (LEO) platforms is imminent. This presents an opportunity for private entities like SpaceX to fill the gap.

In 2021, the U.S. budget for the ISS, including launch costs, was \$2.9 billion. NASA has also projected a budget of over \$9 billion through 2025 for crewed missions to the ISS. It is clear that the demand for a LEO platform remains substantial.

The cooperating agencies on the ISS currently spend approximately \$4.5 billion per year, with half allocated for productive missions and the other half for operations and maintenance. Given the nearing decommissioning of the ISS, this spending could potentially be redirected toward new platforms.

SpaceX, with its experience in orbital technology and a focus on reusability, is well-positioned to provide a solution. The company could capitalize on this opportunity by developing its own LEO platforms, potentially securing a share of the budgets that have historically been directed towards ISS operations.

Space-based AI compute and semiconductor manufacturing

An emerging frontier for SpaceX is orbital computing infrastructure. Having combined its launch, satellite internet, direct-to-mobile, and space-based compute ambitions with xAI's AI assets into a single platform through its acquisition of xAI, SpaceX is pursuing a constellation of up to one million AI data-center satellites as a core growth vector competing for the \$200 billion cloud services market. SpaceX is in active talks with Google to explore co-hosting data centers in orbit, a partnership that would validate enterprise demand for orbital compute infrastructure and could anchor early revenue for the satellite constellation program.

SpaceX's vertical integration ambitions extend into semiconductor manufacturing through Terafab, a multi-phase chip fabrication facility planned for Texas projected to cost up to \$119B, targeting semiconductor self-sufficiency for its AI satellite constellation and establishing SpaceX as a vertically integrated competitor in the global chip manufacturing market. Tesla has signed a contract with Samsung Electronics to produce its next-generation AI6 chip at Samsung's Texas facility through 2033, forming part of the broader supply chain for this buildout.

Risks

Capital and profitability risks: SpaceX's draft IPO prospectus disclosed a nearly \$5B GAAP loss in 2025—tied to costs absorbed from the xAI merger—while simultaneously carrying approximately \$17B in combined space and AI cash burn and up to \$119B in planned Terafab capital expenditure. Elon Musk has warned of "genuine risk of bankruptcy" if Starship fails to achieve a flight rate of at least once every two weeks.

Index inclusion and governance risk: Bloomberg reported that SpaceX's June 2026 IPO is rewriting rules around blockbuster listings, with an accelerated pathway toward index inclusion that could compel roughly \$400B of passive buying, creating significant price dislocation and volatility. Super-voting Class B shares give Musk approximately 83.5–83.6% of voting power post-IPO, meaning public shareholders bear economic risk without commensurate governance rights.

Acquisition and integration overreach: SpaceX is simultaneously absorbing the xAI merger, fielding hints of a Tesla combination, exploring a potential T-Mobile acquisition, and now developing a consumer AI handset prototype—each representing a distinct regulatory, operational, and capital integration challenge layered onto a company still transitioning to public-market accountability.

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